

"THE BJP RAISES COMMUNAL ISSUES TO POLARISE. THEY ARE TRYING TO CHANGE THE CORE OF WHAT RAM IS. THE RESPONSE TO THIS IS CULTURAL"

Q. What is the objective behind the Bhent Mulaqat Abhiyan?
We introduced many schemes, but were unable to go to the ground, to the villages, to see their rollout in the two Covid-hit years. So, the idea is to come to the villages, see the impact of the schemes and hear from people if they are genuinely getting the benefits. I will go to three villages in each assembly constituency, sit under a tree or in a *bageecha* with villagers. If things are satisfactory, it's fine. Any scope for improvement can be suggested and if lapses are found on the part of officers, immediate action will be taken.

Q. Most schemes of your government, be it loan waiver, paddy procurement, cow dung procurement or money to landless labour, are rural-oriented. As a political strategy, do you think it will pay off? Doesn't the Congress need urban seats? Can you face a backlash from them?
No, not at all. If I spend the day in three villages, I spend the night in towns. I meet people there and have a separate set of schemes for urban areas. Otherwise, Chhattisgarh would not have won the award for the cleanest state three times on a trot. We are allowing conversion of land to freehold, and have brought out an industrial policy. If people were not happy in urban areas, Congress would not have won all 14 municipal corporations in the state, including Raipur.

Q. Have you taken a leaf out of the BJP playbook by bringing in beneficiary-oriented schemes wherein you put money in the hands of people and reap political benefits? Doesn't welfarism need to be linked to productivity somewhere?
Chhattisgarh's schemes were not inspired by BJP governments. The Nyay scheme was brought by then party president Rahul Gandhi. The BJP did not ask for votes on the basis of work, but on surgical strikes and Pulwama. On the basis of the Swaminathan Committee report, our government decided to give remunerative prices for paddy at Rs 2,500 a quintal. We pay people who work hard. People who are poor and don't have land are getting Rs 7,000 a year. We are buying cow dung, used for making vermicompost. The land is getting nutrients and cattle are being made productive. Our schemes are not freebies, they help increase productivity.

Q. Coming back to Bhent Mulaqat, the BJP is saying that your tours are actually exposing the real ground situation—how there is little by way of delivery of schemes. Also, it says the Congress is rattled by internal surveys that don't suggest a very rosy picture. What do you think?
I am asking people in public if schemes are reaching them. By and large, people tell me they are getting benefits, but there is scope for improvement in some schemes. As for popularity, if we weren't popular, we would not have won four byelections, most recently in Khairagarh, which was not even the Congress's seat, that too by 20,000 votes.

Q. For the first time, religious issues are taking centrestage in Chhattisgarh. How do you plan to counter it?
The BJP raises communal issues to ensure polarisation. The response to this challenge is cultural. Chhattisgarh has a unique culture, of tribes, festivals such as Hareli, Teej, Karma Jayanti, traditions like Dev Garhi, tribal dance festivals, which we are reviving. We are also bringing to the fore an alternative view of Ram, one that has been sidelined. Ram is being made into Rambo—Ram wasn't ever like that. The message of Ram Rajya has equality and peace as its fundamentals. Hanuman is the trimurti of Shakti, Bhakti and Gyaan. Now you see flags and stickers portraying an aggressive Hanuman. The BJP is trying to change the core of what Ram and Hanuman are.

Q. A strong PESA (Panchayats Extension to Scheduled Areas) Act has been proposed in the state. This is leading to conflict between tribes and backward classes. Will additional rights be given to tribes under PESA?
The PESA Act has been in force in Chhattisgarh for long, only rules under the Act need to be drafted. This is being done and they will be put up before the cabinet soon. We must ensure that gram sabhas in PESA areas need to be representative. If OBC and general categories are 40 per cent of the population, they need to be represented in the sabhas. We will ensure a politics of coordination before we move ahead on PESA rules. ■